



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
DUKE FUQUA

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

In its relatively short history, The Fuqua School of Business at Duke University has established itself as one of the leading MBA programs in the world. Based in Durham, North Carolina, Duke is part of the world-renowned Research Triangle Park (RTP), one of the oldest and largest science parks in the US with over 200 companies ranging from startups to multinational organizations. In fact, the Triangle area has recently received national recognition as one of the best places for business and careers.

Fuqua and Duke see themselves as a vital part of this growth. They are looking for individuals who want to do well in business, but also want to make a positive impact their community and the world. (Prominent alumni include Apple CEO Tim Cook and philanthropist Melinda Gates.) The Fuqua culture is incredibly collaborative and close-knit – Team Fuqua isn't just a saying, but a commitment that the students, faculty and staff make to one another (which extends to partners of students). Fuqua may have a reputation for marketing & general management, but consulting has quickly become a major area of focus; six of its top 10 employers were consulting firms last year.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Health Sector Management, Marketing, Technology, Social Entrepreneurship, Entrepreneurship & Innovation

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 3,557 MBA Class Size: 440
Admissions Selectivity: 22% Yield: 56.23%
Total Tuition: \$136,400

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Consulting 32%; Financial Services 16%; Technology 28%; Healthcare 9%
Top Recruiters: Amazon, McKinsey, Deloitte, Microsoft, Bain & Co., PricewaterhouseCoopers, Accenture, BCG, Google
Avg. Base Salary: \$122,989 Employment in 3 months: 96%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	6	–	1	8	3	6	15	–
Financial Times	8	11	10	11	12	13	12	19
Forbes	–	8	–	12	–	14	–	–
The Economist	19	18	18	14	13	13	13	18
US News	12	11	14	13	12	12	11	10

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 29 yrs Avg. GMAT: 704 Avg. GPA: 3.49
Int'l Students: 38% Female Students: 42%

Deadlines for 2019-2020:

Early Action: Sept. 19, 2019
R1: Oct. 14, 2019
R2: Jan. 6, 2020
R3: Mar. 11, 2020

Sources: Duke Fuqua, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, Forbes, The Economist, US News, MBA50

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ESSAYS 2019-2020

This year, Duke Fuqua has revised the short-answer essays and asks for only two replies (versus three). Its two longer-response essays remain the same.

New short-answer essays:

1. Why is pursuing an MBA the right next step for you? (500 characters, or about 100 words)
2. What are your post-MBA career goals? Share with us your first-choice career plan and your alternate plan. (500 characters, or about 100 words)

Required essay #1: 25 random things about yourself

Instructions: Present your response in list form, numbered 1 to 25. Some points may be only a few words, while others may be longer. Your complete list should not exceed two pages.

For context: Fuqua believes different types of people, points of view, and experiences bring out the best in everyone. And above all, we place a premium on succeeding while making a positive impact on businesses, organizations, and the world. These ways of thinking set the Duke MBA experience apart, and this concept extends beyond the student body to include faculty, staff, and administration. When a new person joins the Admissions team, we ask that person to share with everyone in the office a list of "25 Random Things About Yourself." As an Admissions team, we already know the new hire's professional and academic background, so learning these "25 Random Things" helps us get to know someone's personality, background, special talents, and more.

In this spirit, the admissions committee also wants to get to know you—beyond the professional and academic achievements listed in your resume and transcript. You can share with us important life experiences, your likes/dislikes, hobbies, achievements, fun facts, or anything that helps us understand what makes you who you are. Share with us your list of "25 Random Things" about YOU.

Required essay #2: The Fuqua community and you

Instructions: Your response should be no more than two pages in length.

Fuqua prides itself on cultivating a culture of engagement. Our students enjoy a wide range of student-led organizations that provide opportunities for leadership development and personal fulfillment, as well as an outlet for contributing to society. Our student-led government, clubs, centers, and events are an integral part of the student culture and are vital to providing you with a range of experiential learning and individual development experiences.

Based on your understanding of the Fuqua culture, how do you see yourself engaging in and contributing to our community outside of the classroom?

Optional essay: Tell us more

If you feel there are circumstances of which the admissions committee should be aware (such as unexplained gaps in work, choice of recommenders, inconsistent or questionable academic performance), please explain them in an optional essay.

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By Catherine Finch Tuttle

Catherine brings deep MBA experience as a former Associate Director at Duke University's Fuqua School of Business. For five years she worked in the Career Management Center creating, implementing, and evaluating programs and coaching MBA's to achieve their career goals. She also served as the liaison to Admissions having worked with them earlier in her career as a Marketing Manager.

Tip #1 – Get Personal

The prompt for the 25 Random Things essay clearly states that Admissions wants to get to know you beyond the professional and academic achievements listed on your resume. This is your opportunity to showcase a different side of yourself that may not come through in traditional MBA applications. It's also the opportunity to connect on a personal level. It is what draws the committee in and, if done right, leads them to advocate for you throughout the process. Think about your values, your hobbies, your interests and important life experiences. These can and should be a mix of poignant, humorous, playful, deep, sad and everything in between. Some may be a paragraph whereas others may be a simple sentence. Also keep in mind that they should resonate with the core values of the Fuqua community – collaboration, diversity, honesty, respect and giving back to a cause greater than yourself.

Tip #2 – Know what Team Fuqua means to you

On the surface, Team Fuqua can seem like a tagline or gimmicky slogan, but that's far from the truth. Typically, applicants who devote the necessary time to networking with students and alumni will start to understand what this means on a deeper level. They will hear stories about how students who are competing for the same internship help each other prepare for their interviews, how willing current students are to connect across programs, how alumni continue to engage with the school long after graduation, and how faculty and staff host international students over holiday breaks when they are unable to return to their home country. The sum of the Fuqua community is truly greater than the individual parts and the stories are endless. You need to share your experience and understanding of this deeply relational value throughout your application. 'Tell me what Team Fuqua means to you' is also a favored question among interviewers – both current students and alumni!

Tip # 3 – Envision yourself on campus

The second essay asks you how you see yourself contributing to the community outside the classroom. *Outside the classroom* is key. All too often applicants ignore that part of the prompt and wax poetic about how their experience will add value in class discussions. You must go deeper. Fuqua boasts 60+ student clubs, each of which was started and run by students. These clubs and other experiential opportunities allow you to take initiative and flex the leadership muscle they are building in the program. Think about the groups you will be a part of – professional clubs and those that are more light hearted like the Outdoors Club and Wine Club. Then, reflect on your past experience and how it will contribute to Fuqua's mission/goals. If you talk to club members, you'll be even better equipped to articulate how you can add value in vivid detail.

Tip # 4 – Be clear about your career goals & why Fuqua

At Fuqua, Admissions and the Career Management Center (CMC) are well connected. Career Center staff educate the team on what to look for in resumes and the key skills/experience required for certain career paths. If questions arise about a candidate, their experience, and how realistic their goals are, they will bring in the Associate Dean of the CMC to get her feedback. That said, you need to be quite clear about your development so far, the specific experience/skills needed from the Duke MBA, and how it all translates short- and long-term.

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Tip #5 – Have a viable plan B

While you don't get a lot of real estate to discuss your plan B, this is an incredibly important part of your application. The MBA is a dynamic and transformative experience. At orientation, the Dean of the CMC often jokes about how every year, 80% of the First-Year class will change their career goals. They don't expect everyone to stick with their original plan whether they intend to or not, but they do want to see that you have thought clearly about more than one option and how that will get you to your goals short- and long-term. That way, when the wind changes (and it will), you will be prepared to adjust your sails!

Tip #6 – Highlight cultural competency

Fuqua has always put an emphasis on diversity and takes pride in the fact that its student body is consistently around 40% international. In fact, the main hallway is lined with flags representing the many countries students come from. Teams are purposefully made of individuals from different genders, ethnicities, and functional and industry backgrounds. It's important that your savvy self- and cultural awareness shines throughout your application. Look for ways to stress your experience working with globally diverse teams and why a global perspective is important to you personally and professionally.

Tip #7 – Ask for an alumni recommendation

Finally, in Team Fuqua spirit, alumni tend to remain engaged long after graduation and their opinion is greatly valued by Admissions. So much so, that Fuqua encourages students and alumni who have met with prospective candidates to share direct feedback through an online submission if they feel a candidate is a good fit for the program. (When this happens, Fuqua will waive your application fee.) It's a win-win for all involved, and a nod to the invaluable wisdom of networking with Fuqua alumni throughout your application process. If you have a great connection with an alum you've cultivated, it's okay to ask for an explicit recommendation.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)
